FOOD
TREND

MANNA FROM HEAVEN

Bread, one of the most simple and enduring staples, is having its moment. So much so that bread is The Dish right now. Here's to the rise and rise of artisanal breads.

By Nivedita Jayaram Pawar

The bread scene is heating up. While artisanal bread including sourdough has been trending for some time, there seems to be a growing interest and appreciation for handcrafted loaves. Speciality bake houses are now experimenting with various flours, flavours and techniques to create unique and delicious breads. From cheesy and savory brioches to Korean buns and millet baguettes, there's a wide range of options to satisfy every taste bud.

The bread landscape

Much before the Portuguese introduced warm loaves of poie to India, via Goa, flatbreads such as rotis, puris and parathas were a mainstay of Indian cooking. While the saffron-flavored milk bread sheermal was brought to India by Persian invaders, the Mughal added the tandoori rotis, naans and kulchas to the repertoire. Bread is, after all, the original slow food. It requires space, knowledge, talent and most significantly—time, just like a good stock.

Interest in baking really soared in many countries during the lockdown when a lot of people learned how to bake as a way to escape the craziness of everyday life and the never-ending bad-news-cycle. Today, although the threat of COVID-19 feels less immediate and there are no yeast or flour shortages, artisanal breads are once again having a moment in the sun. The Internet is still cramped with videos of people pulling intricately scored loaves out of ripping hot ovens and showing off their "crumb shots." "In the past, bread was often just a